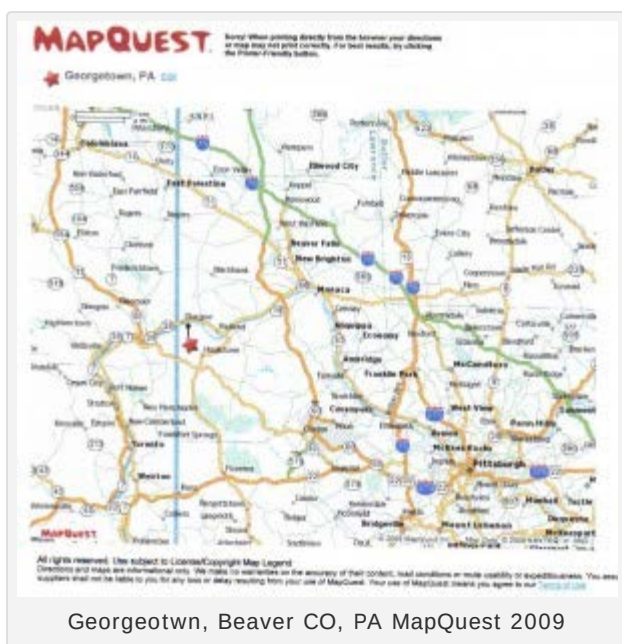




It Used To Be A River Town

Georgetown stands pleasantly on the south bank of the Ohio River on a plateau of high grade sand safe from floods and within sight of Ohio and West Virginia. It was always a great place for rivermen. For more than a century it was known to every traveler going down the river to "the West". Travelers were greeted by a picture card sight of beautiful homes with big porches and picture windows facing the water, two churches with the prettiest commons this side of New England, tree lined streets and wrought iron fencing, hotels, and a general store. All this was within earshot of a steam whistle and the occasional calliope.



One of the oldest settlements in Beaver County, Georgetown was laid out on Jan 13, 1793 by Benoni Dawson who came from Montgomery County, MD, about

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- » [Capt Benjamin M Laughlin](#)



Georgetown, PA Photo by Don Parker ca 1960 (Anna L and John F Nash Collection)

1780. Benoni Dawson had purchased two-hundred-twelve acres and forty-three perches of land from Robert D

Dawson who had received it from the government of Pennsylvania for his service during the Revolutionary War. The patent number was P-15-269 and it was named "The Bone of Contention". The deed can be found in Book E Page 244 at the Allegheny County Court House. Upon the establishment of Beaver Co, it was also recorded in the Office of Deeds for Beaver County Book A Page 162. Frances and John Finley also have an original copy of the deed for Georgetown. See endnote 1.



Deed for Georgetown Frances and John Finley Collection)

In 1750, both VA and PA claimed land south of the Ohio River and west of the Youghioghny River. George Washington was sent to the area in 1753 by the Gov Dinwiddie of Virginia to investigate the strength of the French and to keep Pennsylvanians from settling in their VA commonwealth land. At that time, the French claimed the land on the north side of the Ohio River. Georgetown was the center of this contention in its early history. The government of VA financed the survey of the western boundary of PA which was completed on Aug 23, 1785. Like the Mason Dixon Line, there were two surveyors: David Rittenhouse from PA and Andrew Ellicott from VA, but the boundary has become known

historically as the Ellicott Line. Not only did the two commonwealths contest the ownership of Georgetown area, six counties within the commonwealth of PA governed the area over fifty years. According to the PA government view in 1750, the land which would become Georgetown was in Cumberland Co; in 1771 it was in Bedford Co; in 1773 Westmorland Co; in 1781 Washington Co; in 1788 Allegheny Co; and finally in 1800 Beaver Co was established. So depending on the date, Georgetown was governed by different authorities as settlers moved west.

Another little known but importance part of American history near Georgetown was the [Point of Beginning](#). The [Point of Beginning](#) was

- » [The BM Laughlin Book](#)
- » [The Book p1-43](#)
- » [The Book p45-85](#)
- » [The Book p87-125](#)
- » [The Book p127-163](#)
- » [The Book p165-205](#)
- » [The Book p207-294](#)
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- » [Pitt and Cin Packet Line](#)
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- » [Old Pitt-Cin Packet Line](#)
- » [Missouri River Commerce](#)
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- » [TS Calhoon's Book 1866](#)
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associated with the Rittenhouse and Elliot survey marking the point directly across the river from Georgetown of the western boundary of PA and the Northwest Territory. This mark was the starting point for the survey of all public land west including Alaska.

The town name was originally written as George Town. Although the name change probably occurred officially when the village was incorporated into a borough on Apr 15, 1850 around that time there was a tendency to combine or shorten city names.

There are several theories as to the origin of the name. The most likely one is that the name was bestowed in honor of George Dawson, the son of the founder Benoni Dawson. George Dawson owned of a portion of the town land at the time the borough was established. According to Jess R Finley in his Genealogical History of the Mackall Family in America, Georgetown was named to honor George Dawson, the uncle of Benoni Dawson. Uncle George Dawson had settled in Fayette County, PA in 1770. Benoni Dawson also lived in Fayette Co for seven years before migrating to Georgetown in 1782. The least likely theory is that the town was named in honor of George Washington.

The act to incorporate Georgetown was House of Representatives File No 570 read – February 28, 1850. Frances and John Finley have an original copy of the act read before the PA House of Representatives. See End Note 2.



PA House of Representatives Act to incorporate Georgetown (France and John Finley Collection)

[2]

From the proceedings of the burgess and town council under the act of assembly incorporating Georgetown, the first election of officers was held on May 17, 1850. The officers were:

- » [Poe Glass Plate Negatives](#)
- » [Indian Rocks](#)
- » [Point of Beginning Photos](#)
- » [Maps and Deeds](#)
- » [Catalogue of Deeds](#)
 - » [Lots 19&20 1833](#)
 - » [Lots 19&20 1850](#)
 - » [Lot 21 1804](#)
 - » [Lot 21 1850](#)
 - » [Poe Wood 1850](#)
 - » [Map 17 Dec 1847](#)
 - » [Map 1876](#)
- » [Letters and Papers](#)
 - » [Ltr WH Turner](#)
 - » [Ltrs Jacob Poe](#)
 - » [Ltrs William A Calhoon](#)
 - » [Ltr Adam Poe 22 Mar 1849](#)
- » [Georgetown Methodist Church](#)
- » [St Luke's Episcopal Church](#)
- » [Georgetown Cemetery](#)
 - » [Georgetown Cemetery File](#)
- » [Steamboating Poe Ancestry](#)
- » [Value of the US Dollar](#)
- » [Recommended Reading List](#)
- » [Acknowledgements](#)

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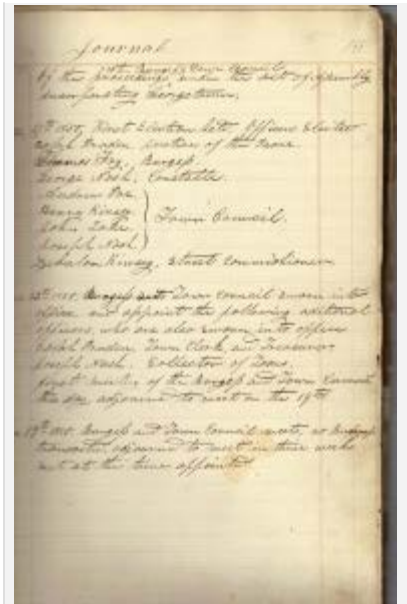
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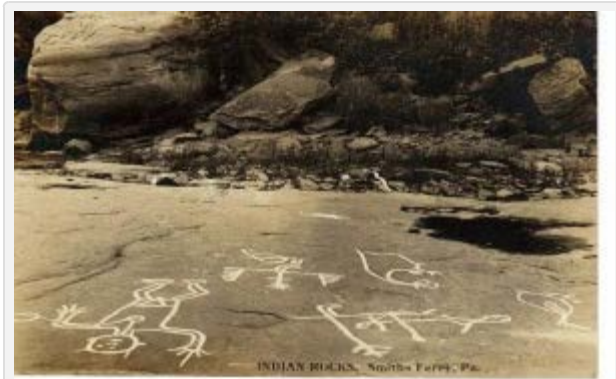
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- » [UW LaCrosse Historic Steamboat Photographs](#)



First Election under PA House Act
(Frances and John Finley
Collection)

Thomas Fry	Burgess
George Nash	Constable
Andrew Poe	Town Council
Henry Kinsey	Town Council
John Lake	Town Council
Joseph Nash	Town Council
Zebulon Kinsey	Street
Commissioner	
SM Prudens	Justice of the
Peace	

Directly across the river is the borough of Glasgow and the village of Smith's Ferry where now covered by water are historic Indian Rocks. These rocks have Indian petroglyphs last seen in the 1960s during the winter when the water level was low. In the 1860's wooden hull steamboats rounding to land found sites like Smith's Ferry dangerous because of the boulders. With its sandy



Indian Pictographs at Smith's Ferry Postcard dated
1908 (Anna L and John F Nash Collection)

beaches and safe location, suitable timber, and good iron works nearby, Georgetown developed a thriving boating industry.

A careful examination of the photos of Georgetown will reveal that the town has little changed in 150 years. The three large homes overlooking the river were built by three of the far



Georgetown 2008 (F Nash Collection)

famed steamboat
captains: Thomas
Stevenson
Calhoon, Thomas
Washington Poe,
and Jackman

Taylor Stockdale.

Here during the golden age of steamboats incredible steamboat stories were told and told again. The tale of an incredible \$50,000 exchanging with a shake of hands on the back porch of a steamboat captain's home was a beggar's delight. Another story detailed the tribute paid a retired river boat captain by boats passing his home. As the captains passed the home, they would salute with a long blow of their whistles at Mile 38.9 from Pittsburgh. A story that unnerved me was that of the body. A steamboat captain who died in St Louis was kept on ice by the Masons until another Georgetown captain could run to St Louis and retrieve the body. As a boy, I heard these tales, but the town folks lives were no longer centered on the river. The town had lost its connection when the ferry ceased operation in 1950.

As railroad service expanded and steamboat traffic declined, Georgetown rivermen were forced to diversify. Oil had oozed out of the Ohio River for years before the first commercial wells were drilled. It was called Seneca Oil, collected in cloths, and used as a cure-all. It was a half-accepted, half fabled remedy for bruises, burns, sprains, and rheumatism. In 1808 Zadok Cramer described the oil in his travel book "The Navigator". Oil, as we know



Oil Lease for George Nash dated 1904
(Anna L and John F Nash Collection)

it, was not discovered until Edwin Drake drilled the first well in Titusville in 1859 – 51 years later. In Georgetown, “oil fever” began in the 1860s.

Speculators began drilling in every direction. By 1864, the local region was producing 35,000 barrels per year.^[15] Wells drilled in Smith’s Ferry produced oil for more than 25 years before they were exhausted. [Thomas S Calhoun](#) turned to the oil business when a well drilled on his farm near Georgetown produced 40 barrels per day. [JT Stockdale](#) in the 1870 Census Report listed his occupation as “Oil Merchant”.

In the 1870's, Georgetown was poised for development. It had resources in abundance to make it one of the most flourishing towns on the Ohio River. In addition to the river business, oil wells had been drilled obtaining oil in paying quantities. For some cause they were abandoned. Either the low price of oil or the difficulty of getting it to market may have been the problem. Coal of good quality was found only 80 feet below the surface. The vein was eight feet which could have been mined at moderate cost. It was not mined. Clay used in pottery and fire brick was available in sufficient abundance to justify a factory. No potteries were built. The high level bottom land, some three miles long, presented a beautiful site for a city. Three stores, one public house, a post office, a smith shop, two churches, and a school indicated a place of good character. For want of a little capital and business energy, and perhaps a railroad, Georgetown failed to develop.^[16]

Although seemingly a quiet, idyllic village, in Jan 1900 trouble was brewing in Georgetown. A number of young men had organized a club with the intention of conducting a dance each week. Unfortunately the social function conflicted with the mid-week prayer service of the Methodist Episcopal Church. A number of younger church members were conspicuous by their absence. Rev Hodge, not slow to voice his disapproval, condemned the practice on moral grounds: “Dancing is a seductive amusement instituted by the devil and perpetuated in this town by his agents.” After the service, young men gathered at the door and

threats against the pastor were heard. Rev Hodge continued his remarks in his next sermon, in stronger terms than the week before, denouncing both dancer and dancing. He injected a “veritable bombshell” and the entire congregation suddenly seized with an attack of coughing, sneezing and other expressions of amusement.^[17] The bombshell was not explained, but it brings to minds the Mark Twain hoodoo. Mark Twain said you should never have a preacher and a white horse on the same boat. You had to throw one or the other overboard, and he preferred the preacher.



Red Cross Knitters Picnic aboard a Packet during WWI (anna L and John F Nash Collection)

According to the 2000 census, the population of Georgetown was 182. In 1900, its population was 270. In 1870 the population was 297. The borough population, never large, has steadily declined since its peak during the golden age of steamboats. The perception that Georgetown has been in decline was voiced much

earlier in its history. In 1807 a traveler F Cummings wrote in his journal of Georgetown, “Though it is a post town, and a considerable thoroughfare of travellers, it is nevertheless on the decline...”.^[18] On Sep 4, 1803 Meriweather Lewis stopped in Georgetown as he was beginning his expedition to explore the Louisiana Territory. Lewis unfavorably described Georgetown as a town “consisting of about a dozen log cabins, one-fourth of which are taverns...”. Lewis bought a replacement pirogue (canoe) in Georgetown to ferry supplies for the expedition. The cost was eleven dollars. He felt cheated. The pirogue leaked badly; supplies got wet; guns rusted. The canoe sunk approximately 20 miles downstream. On 9 Sep 1803, Lewis purchased another pirogue in Wheeling.

In 1805, there were four tavern keepers and two mercantile stores in Georgetown. The Red Lyon tavern operated by John Cameron was favored by rivermen. The first postmaster, Thomas Foster, was appointed on Apr 1, 1802. Thomas Foster also licensed the first hotel. In 2008, Georgetown still retained its US post Office, but it had no stores, no inns, and no taverns.



General Store Frank Calhoon? (Anna L and John F Nash Collection)



General Store with John F Nash ca 1946
(AnnaL and John F Nash Collection)



Smith's Ferry Yacht (Frances and John Finley Collection)

When the ferry ceased operation in 1950 after 150 years of service, Georgetown became more isolated. The river, the natural highway to the



Georgetown Hotel Lillian Poe and Sarah Peppard
(anna L and John F Nash Collection)



Francis Nash on Deserted Market St (Beaver Valley
Times 4 Jun 1955) (Anna L and John F Nash
Collection)

west, brought life to the town. Today the only remaining access is the winding road from Hookstown. Local pranksters, sensing the future, modified a road sign some years ago to read "World Ends, Four Miles". "It used to be a river town," said Lillian Poe Wagner sadly in an interview as she looked along the deserted streets of the once busy village. "Almost everyone was connected with the river in some way." [\[19\]](#)

By 1900, historic Georgetown was almost forgotten by the river. Georgetown declined as Aliquippa, Midland, East Liverpool, and other nearby towns with manufacturing

plants prospered. Today Georgetown is a living ghost town. The old family names are well gone and dispersed. Many of the old homes are in decline. Younger people almost have to leave to find proper work. It was once a beautiful place. It used to be a river town.

References.

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- [\[1\]](#) I held this document in my own hands thanks to the courtesy of Frances Finley.
- [\[2\]](#) I held this journal of the business affairs of the Georgetown council from 1850 to 1867 in my hands thanks again to the courtesy of Frances Finley.
- [\[3\]](#) Charles Dana Gibson and E Kay Gibson, *Dictionary of Transports and Combatant Vessels Steam and Sail Employed by the Union Army 1861 –*

1868, (Ensign Press, Cambridge, MA 1995), p 152.

[4] Capt Frederick Way, Jr., *History in Houses*, (S&D Reflector (Dec 1969)).

[5] Capt Frederick Way, Jr., *The Steamboating Poe Family*, (S&D Reflector) (Dec 1965)).

[6] Arthur B Fox, *Pittsburgh during the Civil War, 1860-1865*, p. 31-32.

[7] Internet *Complete History of the 46th Illinois Veteran*

[8] New York Times Aug 15, 1864.

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[11] John Newton, *A Century and a Half of Pittsburg and Her People*, (Lewis Pub Co 1908), pg 312.

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[13] [13] Charles Dana Gibson and E Kay Gibson, *Dictionary of Transports and Combatant Vessels Steam and Sail Employed by the Union Army 1861 – 1868*, (Ensign Press, Cambridge, MA 1995), p 223.

[14] J Dillon and Son, *M. E. Church in Georgetown*, (The Georgetown Chronicle, (Nov 1877)), pp 4.

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[18] Rev Joseph Bousan, AM, *History of Beaver County Pennsylvania*, (The Knickerbocker Press, New York 1904).

[19] George Swetman, *Life and Death of a River Town*, The Pittsburgh Press, Sunday, Apr 27, 1969.

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